

HONG WANG

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Appointments

Harvard University, Department of Economics
Mary Beth and Chris Gordon Postdoctoral Fellow in Gender Inequality

Aug. 2026–Mar. 2027

Education

Boston University
Ph.D. in Economics
M.A. in Political Economy

Sep. 2020–Aug. 2026 (expected)

Aug. 2024

New York University
B.A. in Mathematics and Economics, *cum laude*

May 2018

Fields

Primary Fields: Economic History, Political Economy
Secondary Fields: Gender Economics, Media Economics
Methods: Historical Data Construction, Natural Language Processing, Deep Learning, Geospatial Analysis

References

Martin Fiszbein
Boston University
fiszbein@bu.edu

James Feigenbaum
Boston University
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Robert Margo
Boston University
margora@bu.edu

Claudia Goldin
Harvard University
cgoldin@harvard.edu

Melissa Dell
Harvard University
melissadell@fas.harvard.edu

Research

Research Assistant to James Feigenbaum, Boston University

2022–2023

Research Grants

BU Institute for Economic Development Research Grant, Boston University, \$3,000

2025

Teaching

Teaching Fellow, Introductory Microeconomics and Macroeconomics, Boston University

2021–2025

Academic Service

Organizer, BU–Harvard Summer Deep Learning in Economics Reading Group

Summer 2024

Job Market Paper

What Killed the ERA? The Role of Entrepreneurs in the Marketplace of Ideas and Policy
I provide the first causal estimates of Phyllis Schlafly’s influence on public opinion and legislative behavior during the Equal Rights Amendment ratification fight. Exploiting quasi-random topographic variation in CBS *Spectrum* radio and television exposure, I find that exposed counties in five pivotal states experienced a 0.21 standard deviation decline in sentiment toward women’s rights. In Illinois, a one standard deviation within-district increase in CBS FM exposure reduced legislators’ ERA support by 18.4 percentage points. CBS television exposure and geochemically instrumented CBS AM exposure increased legislators’ adoption of Schlafly’s ERA framing.

Working Papers

Grounded: Soil Geochemistry and the Causal Effects of Political AM Radio

I show that applying the Irregular Terrain Model to historical AM radio introduces non-classical measurement error because the model is designed for FM frequencies and terrain obstruction. I implement the physically appropriate Low Frequency/Medium Frequency ground-wave model and develop path-integrated geochemical instruments for soil-conductivity-driven propagation. The corrected approach recovers a negative causal effect of Father Coughlin's broadcasts on FDR's 1936 vote share, but no causal effect of Nazi AM radio exposure on Nazi electoral support.

A Republic, Not a Democracy: The Legacy of John Birch Society Membership

I digitize and geocode comprehensive 1987 John Birch Society membership rolls, recovering 45,188 members from 1,870 pages of archival dot-matrix printing using a custom deep-learning OCR pipeline. Counties with more JBS members produced significantly more Department of Justice-charged January 6 defendants, fully absorbing the manufacturing-decline variable emphasized in prior work, while showing less populist electoral shift toward Donald Trump. The paper links contemporary political extremism to long-standing conservative organizational infrastructure.

A Choice, Not an Echo: Cultural Matching in the Marketplace of Ideas and Policy

I develop a nonpriced search-and-matching model in which dormant arguments become powerful only when accumulated idea stock meets accumulated unmet demand through a scarce cultural entrepreneur. The model formalizes activation as a three-input matching problem—dormant stock, unmatched demand, and scarce matcher—and separates platform intensity, which moves attitudes and votes, from transmissibility, which moves rhetoric.

Papers in Progress

The Evangelical Origins of the Welfare Queen

with Brianna Alderman and Gabby Toborg

Using Christian media exposure, we study whether substitution between private charity and public welfare created incentives for churches to advocate against the welfare state by turning congregational sentiment against welfare recipients.

Deep Learning for Census Linking

with Abhishek Arora and James Feigenbaum

Using Sentence-BERT, we develop cosine-similarity methods to improve name-variant disambiguation over time for historical census record linkage.

Seminars & Conferences

Harvard University, Economic History Graduate Workshop
London School of Economics, Queer Conference

2023, 2024, 2025
2025

Additional Experience

Mentor, Minds Matter Boston
Independent study and travel
Fellow, Global Citizen Year, Florianópolis, Brazil

2022–2025
2018–2020
2013–2014

Languages, Software Skills, and Citizenship

Languages: English, Italian, Portuguese

Software Skills: Python, PyTorch, QGIS, L^AT_EX

Citizenship: United States